“How Would We Know Something Had Changed?”

Eight questions families ask while Dad is managing at home.

Dad is managing, and your questions haven't felt pressing enough to take to anyone. They're good questions all the same. Here are eight that families ask at this point, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about Dad in particular. Where a question needs someone who knows him, the answer says who to ask.

1 Nothing is wrong. Is it too early to write anything down?

No. The National Institute on Aging says the best time to think about long-term care is before you need it, because planning gives you and your family time to learn about the services available in your community. A dated page about an ordinary week is simple to write while the week is ordinary. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you'd like someone to look over what you've written. A routine visit with his doctor is a reasonable place to bring it.

2 What support does Dad need today?

Start with what you can see: the tasks in his week, what he does himself, what he gets a hand with, and from whom. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests writing your answers on a sheet of paper, and the National Institute on Aging says the best way to know what someone needs is to ask them directly. So ask Dad, and let him correct the page. What you'll have is a description of today's help, which is the part a family can supply. [2] [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know whether the help he has is the help he needs. That takes an assessment, and it belongs to his doctor or your care consultant.

3 Can't we work out what's coming from his age or his health?

Not reliably. The National Institute on Aging says it can be difficult to predict how much or what type of care a person might need, and the Administration for Community Living says the duration and level of care vary from person to person and often change over time. A family's timeline is a guess, however carefully it's argued. A record of today isn't. [1] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know what a health condition of his could mean for the years ahead. That's a question for his doctor.

4 The help at home works. Can't we just count on it?

You can count on it and still write down what it rests on: he drives, a neighbor is home in the daytime, the stairs are fine, your brother has Thursdays free. Each is a fact about today. The National Institute on Aging's advice about living at home as you age is to be realistic and plan to revisit the decision as needs change over time, and the CDC suggests updating a family's own care plan every year, or more often if there's a change in health or medicines. Looking again doesn't mean anything is wrong. [1] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** one of the things the arrangement rests on has changed, and you'd like to know what that means for Dad.

5 How would we know something had changed?

By having something to compare against. With a dated page, two relatives can read the same line and agree whether it's different now. Which changes matter isn't something the family has to decide. Ask his doctor which ones they'd want to hear about, and write the answer down. As general guidance, the National Institute on Aging says that if you're concerned about a person's physical or mental health, suggest a visit to a health care provider. [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you've noticed something different and can't tell whether it matters. Describe what you saw, with the date, and let them judge.

6 Who would we tell?

Health questions go to his doctor, or to a nurse, therapist or pharmacist he already sees. For finding services nearby, the National Institute on Aging names the Eldercare Locator at 800-677-1116 and your local Area Agency on Aging. The Family Caregiver Alliance describes professional care managers as trained to assess a family's individual situation and as working with the family, the physician and the person receiving care. Whoever it is, Dad is part of the conversation. [1] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can't tell which kind of professional a question belongs to. Start with the one who knows Dad best and ask where it should go.

7 People keep saying “capabilities.” What does that mean, and do we need to know now?

In this roadmap it means what any source of help, at home or elsewhere, is able to do. One distinction is worth knowing. The Administration for Community Living's glossary describes personal care as non-skilled help with things like bathing and dressing, and skilled care as nursing and therapies that usually require a licensed professional such as a nurse, doctor or therapist. You don't need answers now. A short list of questions to ask later is enough. [6]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know which kinds of help Dad would need. Only someone who has assessed him can say.

8 Does planning ahead mean choosing a place?

No. Nothing in this step asks the family to pick one, and the names are less fixed than they sound. The National Institute on Aging notes that exact arrangements for assisted living vary by facility and by state, and the Family Caregiver Alliance says these places may go by different names in your area. What this step asks for is today's record and a list of questions about what Dad would need, whatever the arrangement. [7] [8]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** a relative wants to start comparing places. A professional who knows Dad is the one to say what any arrangement would have to offer him.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about Dad himself. Whether today's help is the right help, what a change would mean and what he might need later all take someone who has assessed him.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the general questions. The care interview is where they become about Dad: it asks about each area of his daily life, one at a time, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. National Institute on Aging, What Is Long-Term Care?
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources
3. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
4. Administration for Community Living, How Much Care Will You Need?
5. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan
6. Administration for Community Living, Glossary
7. National Institute on Aging, Long-Term Care Facilities: Assisted Living, Nursing Homes, and Other Residential Care
8. Family Caregiver Alliance, Residential Care Options: Housing Options

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